

Cataclysm

Erupting volcanoes have caused some of the worst natural disasters in history. The most dangerous volcanoes are not those that erupt frequently, but the ones that have not erupted for centuries. People start living close by, farming the fertile volcanic soil, and even building great cities. But then the volcano erupts again, with catastrophic results.

Laki Iceland



Eruption June 1783–February 1784

Features Huge lava flow, gas cloud

Estimated death toll 9,350

Rift volcanoes usually erupt so regularly that people keep away from them. But sometimes there is no escape. In 1783, the Laki rift in Iceland erupted from more than 140 craters over eight months, releasing vast amounts of lava and poisonous gases. A quarter of Iceland's population died from poisoning and starvation, and the effects of the eruption were felt around the world.

▼ LETHAL RIFT

This is just part of the Laki rift system, which erupted over a total length of 16 miles (26 km) in 1783, producing the largest lava flow of modern times.